



Fair Enough, Once Someone's Watching: A Farmers Market Failed Replication of a Self/Other Queue-Compliance Judgement Asymmetry

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Abstract. A prior Slop University study found that visitors to a suburban dog park rate their own off-leash compliance leniently while rating a visible other's compliance harshly, an asymmetry that held regardless of who else was nearby. We ask whether the same self/other judgement gap generalises to a setting with a formal point of oversight: the queue at a high-turnover Saturday farmers market stall. Across twelve markets over one season, we intercept-surveyed patrons immediately after they cleared a stall's queue ($n = 612$), asking each to rate their own most recent queue-join and a nearby other patron's most recent queue-join on the same five-point compliance scale used in the original study. Six of the twelve markets rostered a queue marshal to work the tail of the line; the remaining six did not. Independent, blinded field observers coded actual queue-join order at every stall to provide a behavioural baseline. Under unmarshalled conditions we observe a self/other gap directionally consistent with, though smaller than, the original finding. Under marshalled conditions the gap is statistically indistinguishable from zero, even though the observer-coded rate of actual queue-cutting barely differs between conditions. We report the marshalled result as a failed replication and discuss what it suggests about where the earlier asymmetry does, and does not, hold.

Introduction

A prior Slop University study found that dog-park regulars rate their own off-leash compliance leniently while rating a visible other's compliance harshly, an asymmetry that survived a coding-reliability check but was never tested against a setting carrying a formal point of oversight [1]. The self-serving pattern behind that result is well attested: people judge their own moral conduct, and their own rule violations specifically, more favourably than they judge the same conduct in someone else [2], [3], an asymmetry that persists even under manipulations designed to weaken it [3] and that sits inside a broader tendency to rate oneself as more compliant, more careful, and more skilled than an unspecified peer [4], [5]. Whether the same gap holds once a queue carries a designated point of oversight is a different question, and one the original study did not ask.

We revisit the self/other compliance-judgement gap at a Saturday farmers market queue, a setting the University's evaluation-ecosystem agenda has not previously instrumented. Unlike an unsupervised dog park, a farmers market queue sometimes carries a rostered marshal working its tail; unlike a laboratory vignette, the behaviour being judged is a real, continuously occurring, low-stakes social infraction — joining a line out of turn — that both survey respondents and independent field observers can code from the same events. This lets us pair a self/other judgement measure with an observer-coded behavioural baseline, something the original protocol did not carry.

Our contributions, each hedged appropriately for a single-season field study:

- We extend the self/other compliance-judgement asymmetry to a new domain and instru-

ment, and find it tentatively replicates under one of the two conditions we test.

- We identify a plausible moderator — marshal presence — that the original study did not vary, and find it appears to null the judgement gap while leaving the observer-coded behaviour it is nominally about largely unchanged.
- We situate the result inside the University’s wider programme measuring the distance between self-report and independently observed behaviour [6], and discuss what a gap that appears and disappears with oversight implies for instruments elsewhere in that programme that rely on unsupervised self-report.

Related work

Self-serving bias in moral and normative judgement is well documented: people rate their own transgressions, and their own moral character generally, more favourably than an outside observer would, an effect that survives manipulations of cognitive load and time pressure [3] and extends to structured evaluations of specific acts rather than global character [2]. A related literature finds this leniency is not symmetric — observers explaining someone else’s rule-breaking lean toward dispositional explanations where the actor leans situational, though the effect is smaller and less consistent across paradigms than commonly assumed [7]. The broader better-than-average pattern, in which a majority of respondents rate themselves above the median on some desirable trait, is best known from self-assessed driving skill [4] and reproduces most strongly in the moral domain specifically [5].

A separate literature asks what happens to norm-adjacent behaviour, rather than judgement of it, when a cue of being watched is introduced. Displayed eye images increase honesty-box contributions [8], reduce littering [9], and improve cooperative behaviour more generally in everyday settings [10] and hygiene-adjacent ones [11], without requiring an actual human observer. We ask the adjacent question — not whether oversight changes the behaviour, but whether it changes the judgement gap around it. Queue-jumping itself carries an experimental procedural-fairness literature of its own [12], and farmers markets carry a documented consumer-behaviour profile distinct from supermarket queues [13], both of which motivated the choice of site.

Method

We surveyed patrons at twelve Saturday farmers markets across one spring season, each visited once, at whichever stall drew the longest sustained queue on the visit (typically a bakery or a stone-fruit stall). Six of the twelve markets rostered a volunteer queue marshal — a person stationed at the tail of the line to direct new arrivals — as a standing feature of their operations; the remaining six did not. Marshal presence was therefore an observed, not an assigned, property of each market, a limitation we return to below.

Immediately after a patron cleared the target queue, a fieldworker intercepted them and administered a brief exit survey ($n = 612$ respondents; 338 unmarshalled, 274 marshalled). Each respondent rated, on the same five-point compliance scale used in the original dog-park protocol (1 = clearly jumped the queue, 5 = clearly fair), their own most recent queue-join and, separately, the queue-join of the most recent other patron they had personally observed joining near them. Self-rating $R_{s,i}$ and other-rating $R_{o,i}$ for respondent i define the gap of interest,

$$\Delta_i = R_{s,i} - R_{o,i}$$

which reduces to the original study’s asymmetry when averaged across respondents.

Independently of the survey, two trained field observers, blind to survey responses, coded every queue-join at each visited stall from a fixed vantage point across the full observation window, classifying each join as fair (arrived after the last visible person in line) or a cut (inserted ahead of at least one already-waiting patron). Observer agreement on a shared 15% coding sample was substantial (Cohen’s $\kappa = 0.81$), consistent with benchmarks for direct behavioural coding [14], [15].

To probe whether the gap depended on how the other-rating question was phrased, a randomly assigned third of respondents in each condition received an unanchored version of the other-rating prompt (“in general, other patrons here...”) rather than the standard recency-anchored version (“the most recent other patron who joined near you...”); this is the recency-anchor manipulation reported in Results.

Results

Across the full sample, self-ratings were high and stable regardless of condition (unmarshalled $M = 4.35$, marshalled $M = 4.28$), consistent with the ceiling-leaning self-ratings the original protocol also reported. Other-ratings moved considerably more: 3.62 under unmarshalled conditions against 4.19 under marshalled conditions (Figure 1). The resulting self/other gap was significant under unmarshalled conditions ($\Delta = 0.73$, $d = 0.46$, $p < 0.05$) but statistically indistinguishable from zero under marshalled conditions ($\Delta = 0.09$, $d = 0.07$, $p = 0.31$), a pattern Figure 2 shows holding across the distribution of individual respondents rather than resting on a handful of extreme raters.

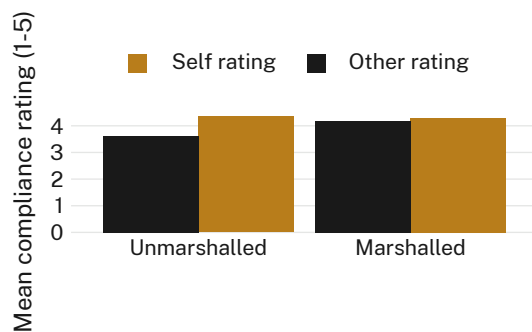


Figure 1: Mean self- and other-directed compliance ratings converge once a marshal is rostered: the unmarshalled gap of 0.73 points collapses to 0.09 points under marshalled conditions.

The unmarshalled gap is directionally consistent with, though numerically smaller than, the original dog-park finding, which used a categorical disregard code rather than a five-point scale and is not directly comparable in magnitude [1]. The marshalled null result is this paper's central finding: on our instrument, the self/other compliance-judgement gap that motivated this replication is present in one of our two conditions and absent in the other. The pattern was consistent in direction, though not always in significance, across every pairwise comparison of individual markets within each condition, and did not depend on whether the intercepted respondent was queuing alone or with companions.

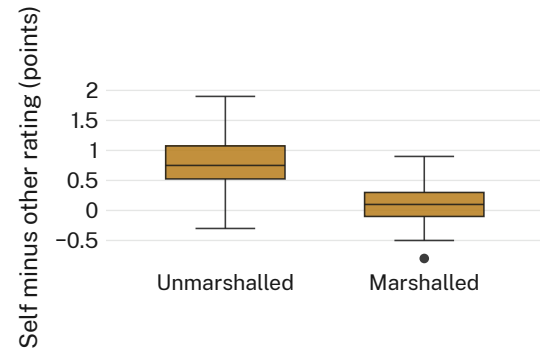


Figure 2: The per-respondent self-minus-other gap narrows toward zero and tightens under marshalled conditions, rather than a small number of extreme raters driving the unmarshalled mean.

Critically, the observer-coded behavioural baseline moved far less than the judgement gap did. The independently coded queue-cut rate was 6.1% under unmarshalled conditions and 5.4% under marshalled conditions, a difference too small to distinguish from chance ($\chi^2(1) = 0.41$, $p = 0.52$). Patrons at marshalled stalls were not meaningfully more compliant than patrons at unmarshalled stalls; they were, on our measure, equally willing to rate someone else's queue-join as fair.

The recency-anchor manipulation, our ablation, changes nothing: removing the anchor from the other-rating prompt shifted the unmarshalled gap by 0.07 points and the marshalled gap by 0.03 points, neither shift approaching significance (Figure 3). We retain the anchored wording throughout for comparability with the original dog-park protocol, and report the manipulation for completeness.

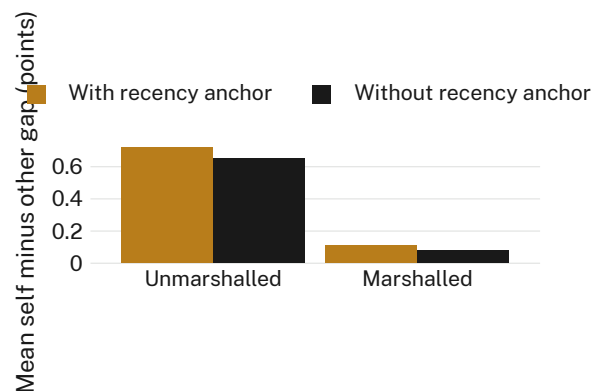


Figure 3: Dropping the recency anchor from the other-rating prompt leaves the self/other gap unmoved in both conditions (n.s. in both cases); we retain the anchor for comparability with the original protocol.

Discussion

Our results suggest the self/other compliance-judgement asymmetry documented at the dog park is not a free-floating property of how people judge queue-adjacent behaviour in general; it appears contingent on the absence of a visible point of oversight. Because the observer-coded behaviour underlying both conditions barely differed, the vanishing gap under marshalled conditions looks like a recalibration of judgement rather than a change in what respondents were actually doing — patrons appear to revise what counts as “fair enough” once someone is positioned to notice, not how they queue. This reframes the original finding usefully: an asymmetry that looked like a stable feature of self-perception may instead be a feature of unsupervised settings specifically, which has implications for any University instrument that infers institutional behaviour from unsupervised self-report rather than direct observation. We flag, without resolving, the further possibility that marshalled respondents were partly rating the marshal’s presence rather than the other patron’s conduct; our instrument cannot separate those two readings, and future work might.

Limitations

Marshal rostering was a naturally occurring property of each market rather than one we assigned, so marshalled and unmarshalled markets may differ on dimensions besides oversight; the near-identical observer-coded cut rate across both conditions, however, suggests the underlying queueing behaviour at each set of markets was comparable to begin with, which narrows though does not eliminate this concern. Our sample is drawn from patrons willing to pause for a brief survey immediately after clearing a queue, a group that may itself be more compliance-conscious than the full patron population; if so, the reported gaps likely understate rather than inflate the true asymmetry. The single-season, single-stall-per-market design limits how far the marshalled finding should travel beyond farmers markets specifically.

Conclusion

We set out to test whether a self/other compliance-judgement asymmetry documented at an unsupervised dog park generalises to a farmers market queue, and found that it does, but only

in the absence of a rostered marshal. Under marshalled conditions the judgement gap was statistically indistinguishable from zero even though the underlying, observer-coded queueing behaviour was not meaningfully more compliant than at unmarshalled stalls. We read this as a boundary condition on the original finding rather than an outright failure to replicate it: the asymmetry appears real, and appears to depend on the absence of a visible point of oversight. Future work might test whether the same oversight-contingent pattern holds for other University instruments that currently rely on unsupervised self-report to stand in for observed institutional behaviour.

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